

# Riccardo Di Cato

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**Placement Coordinator:** Andrew Flores

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## Education

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**University of California San Diego**

2021–present

Ph.D. in Economics (expected 2027)

*Research areas:* Development Economics and Political Economy

*Advisors:* Sara Lowes and Samuel Bazzi (co-chairs); Paul Niehaus, Gaurav Khanna, and Craig McIntosh

**University of Bologna**

2018

M.Sc. in Economics, LMEC (*summa cum laude*)

**University of Pavia**

2016

B.A. in Economics

## Job Market Paper

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Seeds of Market-Based Capitalism: Financial Innovation and China's Modernization *with Jiachen Li*

How do new economic ideas spread across different institutional environments? We examine this question by tracing the adoption of modern finance in China from the late nineteenth century to the present. Before 1936, as modern financial practices spread into China, we show that Christian missionaries contributed to their local adoption. Using a staggered difference-in-differences design, we find that missionary arrival increased modern banks by 31% and enterprises by 27%. Using newly compiled data on mission schools, publications, bankers, and elites, we provide evidence that practical education and knowledge diffusion facilitated the adoption of modern banking. We then estimate the long run effects of missionary exposure after 1949 by using the coincidental timing of railway construction relative to national missionary inflows. The historical banking advantage weakened under central planning but re-emerged after 1978 and remains visible today. Locations with greater historical missionary exposure have higher GDP, more enterprises, and greater foreign investment, indicating that missionaries shaped the geography of China's recent growth. Data on elites, scientists, and educational attainment suggest that the weakening and re-emergence of the banking advantage reflect complementarity between historically formed human capital and a policy environment supportive of market development. Overall, the successful adoption of new ideas requires both the local skills and knowledge needed to adopt them and an institutional environment in which they can be used.

## Work in Progress

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Same Faith, Different Politics: Religious Broadcasting and Voting in Italy and Spain *with Mattia Albertini*

Restricting Online Pornography and Violence Against Women: Evidence from India and the United States *with Santiago Cantillo*

Increasing Female Employment in the Automotive Sector in India *with Garima Sharma, Anant Nyshadham, and Achyuta Adhvaryu*

Religious Broadcasting and Belief Formation in Tanzania *with Mattia Albertini*

## Employment

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|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>National Bureau of Economic Research</b>                                                   | 2022      |
| Research Assistant (Prof. Samuel Bazzi)                                                       |           |
| <b>Bocconi University</b>                                                                     | 2019–2021 |
| Research Associate (Prof. Nicola Limodio and Prof. Filippo De Marco)                          |           |
| <b>Harvard University</b>                                                                     | 2018–2019 |
| Field Research Associate in the DRC (Profs. N. Nunn, J. A. Robinson, S. Lowes, and J. Weigel) |           |
| <b>Entrepreneurial Venture</b>                                                                | 2015–2020 |
| Founded and managed a hospitality business operating three tourist residences in Italy        |           |

## Presentations

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|------------------------------------------------|------|
| SIOE Conference, INSEAD                        | 2026 |
| HHDI–NIDE Workshop, Belfast                    | 2026 |
| IRES Workshop, Chapman University              | 2026 |
| ASREC Conference, Chapman University           | 2026 |
| ASREC Conference, George Mason University      | 2025 |
| SOCAL Conference, UCLA                         | 2025 |
| DevPEC Conference, UC Berkeley                 | 2025 |
| University of Bologna WiP Seminar              | 2025 |
| Migration and Development Conference, Bologna  | 2024 |
| Boston University Center for the Study of Asia | 2024 |

## Teaching Experience

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| <b>University of California San Diego</b>                                                                    | 2021–present |
| <i>Graduate:</i> Financial Accounting; Quantitative Methods II; Quantitative Methods III                     |              |
| <i>Undergraduate:</i> Microeconomics (principles and intermediate); Financial Accounting; The Indian Economy |              |
| <b>Bocconi University</b>                                                                                    | 2020         |
| <i>Undergraduate:</i> Financial Markets and Institutions; Public Finance                                     |              |

## Fellowships, Grants, and Awards

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|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Cindy Vojtech Summer Research Prize in Economics, UC San Diego (\$1,667) | 2026      |
| IHS Research & Travel Grant (\$2,500)                                    | 2026      |
| Summer Research Grant, UC San Diego (\$2,600)                            | 2024–2025 |
| Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics (\$6,885)               | 2023      |
| 21st Century India Center Travel Grant, UC San Diego (\$8,500)           | 2023      |
| TRELS Grant, UC San Diego (\$1,000)                                      | 2022      |
| Overseas Scholarship, Université de Montréal                             | 2018      |
| Erasmus Scholarship, Université Pierre Mendès France                     | 2015      |

## Referee Service

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Journal of Development Economics; Economic Development and Cultural Change, Mission Studies

## Mentoring and Community Involvement

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Co-founder, Undergraduate–Graduate Economic Research Lab, UC San Diego  
 Co-founder and co-host, Backstory Podcast at UC San Diego  
 Organizer and director, church summer camp, Omegna, Italy; college-student mentor  
 Co-founder, “Yes, I Care” community-meeting project; volunteer with Suñu Diwaan, Senegal

## Additional Information

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| <i>Programming</i>   | Stata, R, ArcGIS, L <sup>A</sup> T <sub>E</sub> X, GeoODK (advanced); Python (intermediate); Matlab (basic) |
| <i>Languages</i>     | <i>Native:</i> Italian. <i>Fluent:</i> English, French. <i>Intermediate:</i> Spanish.                       |
| <i>Citizenship</i>   | Italian citizen; U.S. permanent resident                                                                    |
| <i>Personal life</i> | Father of three children (ages 6, 3, and 1); married to a Spanish-American                                  |